Interview Questions – Part B: Open-Ended Qualitative Questions (50 minutes)

Now, I would like to ask some questions to understand your experiences with buying and preparing food and using food assistance programs (such as SNAP or food stamps, food pantries, and school lunch programs) and how refugee organizations have helped you with food.

Questions on food and nutrition insecurity experiences and using food programs (40 minutes)

1. Tell me about your experience in buying and preparing food for your household in the U.S.
    a. Explore where they buy food and groceries, if they have cooking appliances, and if they know how to cook food.

First of all, I have a Costco card. I go get the halal food. I get the beef and lamb chicken cut up into small pieces. I get the halal things for us as muslims. I go again get vegetables, apples, onions, tomatoes, some nuts, pineapple, milk, I get beef, chicken, I get these things. I get bread from the muslim markets and I come back home.

FQ: do you take a car or bus?

I take the car sometimes. When I first moved here,I used to take the bus. I have a card for the bus, IRC gave it to me. Its monthly as refugees we get it for free. It may take me 2 hours to get everything taking the bus.

FQ: Do you have pots and pans?

I have. (are they enough for the portions you need?) yeah. I got them used. Irc gave them to me. As soon as I got here, IRC offered everything I needed as a refugee.

FQ: do you know how to cook?

Of course,I know how to cook. Everyone in this household cooks I have youtube to use when I want to learn how to cook something now.

2. Review answers in the Food Insecurity sections and ask the following questions if they have experienced food insecurity in the last 12 months; if not, go to question #3:
    a. You indicated that you often/sometimes had problems with food in the last 12 months, can you tell me more about that?

    In the first 2 months, I did not have a EBT card. I used to wait for IRC to bring me food. Sometimes they would bring me, I am muslim of course, sometimes they would bring pork. The things that they brought, if I knew it I would eat it. If I didn't know it, I would throw it in the garbage. That's how they we were living, after two months they gave me the food stamps and I was able to get the food that I liked.

    FQ: Do you feel like the grocery stores are close to you?

Honestly with a car they are close but without a car, I have to take the bus and that is far. I go to rancho, and Winco. I got used to rancho and winco. It takes me two buses to getto rancho, I take the 205, and then I continue on the 33. The waiting time is what takes the most time when taking the bus.

Explore the nature of the problem such as unemployment, low income, language barriers, and lack of knowledge about resources.

b. Can you explain what you did to find help with food and if that worked?

If I went to any store and told them that I was a new refugee in America, of course they help you. The situation is easy, I am a refugee and I need help. (where did you go to get help with food?) I used to go to the refugee center, I go to IRC. I go to Utah University Hospital, I go with my buddies and we get some food. The section that is apparently associated with Utah university. We call them all Utah refugee center so we don't differentiate between them. I used to go with people, I never went by myself. I used to go with a group of guys. (did you ever go by yourself?) no.

FQ: what do you think is the cause of the issue with food?

They help the people who need it. The people need it and they need to stand up for the people and help them.

FQ: What do you think is the biggest cause of the issue?

The situation is simple, if you are really in need, if they help you they help you. If they don't they don't. It doesn't matter if you speak English or Arabic, If they want to help you, they will help you.

FQ: do you think if you had a higher income it would help with your food situation?

Of course because If you work and you get a lot of money. You can help your family, afford rent, afford food. You'll buy the things that are good.

FQ: do you know anyone in your community who doesn't know about the help with food that is offered to them?

They know of course. But If you are new, you get help. You have been here a long time and your financial situation is good, of course they wouldn't need it. They help the people who need it.

c. Can you explain how your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> helped you with food?

i. Explore training on budget management, preparing meals, purchasing foods, using food pantries and farmers markets, and applying for food programs such as SNAP.

FQ; you said that they (IRC) used to bring food to your home but what would you say was the amount of food that you were able to eat?

They used to bring a variety of things. Sometimes it would be not enough. The milk would not be enough because they bring 1 liter which would not be enough for one week. Sometimes they bring food every

week, every five days, every two weeks. So sometimes they would go long. In between food delivery time. They did not have consistent times.

FQ: This was the first three months, what happened after that?

After the third month, they gave us food stamps card. I buy food by myself.

FQ: Do you still have food stamps?

No

FQ: how does IRC help you with food now?

At the moment, they stopped all help since I started work.

ii. What has been most useful to you among things that your <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> do?

The thing they helped me the most with was cleaning supplies. The supplies for a shower and things like that. The thing. They would give us the most, because we have enough now.

FQ: did you apply for snap or did they apply for you?

The caseworker applied for us because I don't know how to do these things.

FQ: did you ask for the reason you stopped receiving SNAP?

They said that now you have a job, you have to dependent on yourself.

FQ: if I hypothetically told you to apply for SNAP right now, would you be able to?

No, I don't know how. (do you have a computer?) yes I do (and you have internet?) yeah. The caseworker applied for me. If you are new the caseworker applies for all the paperwork for you like social security, work card, In a year. After a year, they stopped helping.

FQ: would you be able to know that you answered a question wrong on the application? Would there be a language barrier?

Yeah honestly maybe.

iii. Ask those who are still receiving <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> support: Do you feel comfortable finding help with food without the help of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> when you graduate from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

iv. Is there anything that you wish you had learned or could learn from caseworkers of <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to help you with food?

A lot of the people that help me are the ones who speak Arabic. The ones who are muslim. Omar is one of the people who helps me. If he cant help me, he tells me to go to a place where they can help. If he can help me he will help me.

d. Ask those who graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> to determine when food became a problem: Can you tell me when food became a problem?

I do not focus on it like there is a lack of food. I always look for alternative solutions. If I can not find a solution in one spot, I will try my best to look for another solution elsewhere. I don't look at it as if it's a problem.

FQ: when did realize that the food would finish quickly or wouldn't be enough for you?

If the amount that I got was a small amount. If I get a large amount, I don't feel like we don't have enough food. A lot of the money I earn ends up going to rent. I did apply for housing. (did you apply yourself?) My caseworker applied for me.

FQ: do you think your caseworker can help you apply for SNAP again?

I. went to the refugee center and I met with many people. If there was a way to apply. I. would have known about it It, because I know a lot of people at the refugee center. I used to go there and have people. If I have to apply I will talk to them to help me apply.

FQ: when you moved to the states did they show you the places that you can buy groceries from?

Omar talked to me and took me once. But of course you will ask the people. You go out and explore you know where the market is and the food bank. Everytime you walk around the area you are able to learn more.

FQ: do you think IRC helped you more than your community or other way**?**

I helped myself the most. (did you not ask for help or did not receive help?) they will help with what they are capable of doing. There are some things that they can do for me and other things I can do for myself.

FQ: Rancho you found it yourself or they told you about it?

I found it myself. I was exploring and I went into it.

FQ: is there any grocery store they told you about?

Walmart.

FQ: what about food banks?

No, but there was a girl named Yasmin who took me to the refugee center to get food from the food bank. She did not come to take us to the food pantry. She was teaching us about the bus system.As the conversation progressed, I told her I don't have enough food. She told me I could go to the refugee center and they will be help to help you. She told me she would take me there with the car.

e. Review answers in the Utilization section and ask the following questions if they have used SNAP/WIC/NSLP/Food Pantries/Other programs in the last 12 months; if not go to #f below:

SNAP

i. You indicated that you have used XXX program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?

The program helps the people who have a low income or limited income. IRC will apply and give you the card. The card will have a certain amount of money, cash and there will be for food.

FQ: was the cash amount enough when you did not have a job?

No, I would use it to buy the things that I need but it would not be enough for the month. But I used to use the cash. After a couple months, I used to use some of the cash that came from food stamps to buy rent.

ii. Can you explain your experience with using this program? Explore how often they use the program and how they feel about it.

SNAP program is of course a program. That. Helps refugee and they give. You a certain amount of money. You go to the supermarket and get the things you need then head home. Of course it's a good program, it helps the homeless and the people who need it. Any person who needs it regardless of ethnicity or financial state. Of course it's a good thing that helps people.

FQ: do you wish you still had SNAP benefits?

Of course. Any person who wants help. Even if you have a lot of money you will still need this card.

iii. Tell me about the food you received from them.

I used to go to rancho and winco. I also went to this afghani spot named halal market. I used to go to Mustafa to buy bread. Any place that accepts this card I used to go and use it there.

FQ: Mustafa whats the name of his store?

It was a restaurant but we used to get bread from there.

iv. What % of your foods come from this program?

100%

Food pantry

i. You indicated that you have used XXX program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?

I did not apply. You just go give them your name, abd information, zip code, and they are gonna give you food.

FQ: was the application hard?

No

FQ: How did you hear about it?

Yasmin. There would be a variety of things and you only get the things that you want. You get what you want and you come back. Yasmin is who told everyone.

ii. Can you explain your experience with using this program? Explore how often they use the program and how they feel about it.

The situation is good. The purpose is to help the people who need. You go give them your name and family, you get the things that you want and the things that are available and you go back.

FQ: Do you read the ingredients that are in the canned food?

If there is something I don't know, I will not take it. I do not try anything new. Some things may have pork I don't want it.

iii. Tell me about the food you received from them.

A lot of the food is canned. Im scared that it would have pork. I stay away from these things. I only take the things I want and need. I take the things I can ensure is halal.

FQ: Do you feel that you can go and get food that's halal from a food pantry?

Sometimes I go and do not find anything I need.

FQ: would you have food at home?

I would have food at home. If there is something missing, I will go to the food pantry. If I find it I find it, if I don't its okay.

iv. What % of your foods come from this program?

10%.

School lunch programs

i. You indicated that you have used XXX program, can you tell me how you heard about this program and how you applied for it?

We did not apply but you as a student they have to offer you food like breakfast and dinner. They give you meals during the school time from the morning until 4 p.m.

FQ: how did you apply for it?

IRC had to have applied. But I don't know exactly who applied for it. Of course in school they have to be able to help those who need it as a refugee.

FQ: what high school does he go to?

Utah Refugee international, Its made by IRC. It mostly refugees. Maybe 65% of the students are refugees.

ii. Can you explain your experience with using this program? Explore how often they use the program and how they feel about it.

You come at 8, before you go to class, you get breakfast. At 12 something like that, you get a lunch meal and then you go back to class. You go through the school day and come home.

FQ: do you feel relieved knowing that he has food there?

Yes because I talked to them. There was a parent-teacher conference, they tell us everything is good they get breakfast.

FQ: is he able to eat the food that Is offered to him at school?

Yes when you apply you tell them that he is muslim and they only give him the halal food. But of course you have to tell them.

FQ: do they give you food specifically just for you?

I take food with everyone. There is no pork at school.

iii. Tell me about the food you received from them.

They don't give us food to take home

iv. What % of your foods come from this program?

0%

3. Tell me about your experience in finding and buying foods from your culture.
   a. How important eating foods from your culture is to you?

   Of course, you have to eat the things you know and from your culture. But sometimes you might feel the need to try something new. It is something you need to be able to hold onto as a person living in a place where you had to start from 0 so you can not really change everything.

   FQ: so you try to hold onto your culture?

   Yes, hold onto the culture.

   b. Where do you get your vegetables and cultural foods from?

   Of course from the same places. From rancho, from Costco.

   FQ: you find everything that you have in your culture there?

   No, but you get somethings from certain places, some from others.

   FQ: are there times you crave a certain vegetable from your culture but you don't find it?

   No of course everything is available here. Things that are not available here, I let them go.

   FQ: you don't go look for them at the Arabic market?

If you go to the Arabic market and find something you are craving, youll get it. You don't find it, its fine.

FQ: what kind of things do you find at the Arabic market that you want?

Stuff like tormus. Even some date kinds are not available here so I have to get it from there.

FQ: are there vegetables you only get from the Arabic market?

The Arabic market they have ground beef that you can not find in other place. You can not ensure that it is halal. You have to go to halal places and get it.

c. How does/did <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> help you with finding foods from your culture?

No they didn't help,they don't have these things.

   i. What did they do that was the most helpful and why?

d. Do you use Farmers Market to buy foods from your culture?

   I do not know where it is. If I found it I will go. I am looking for it because its organic but I could not find any.

e. Have you used the Sunnyvale Farmers Market (4013 S 700 W)?

   No

   i. if yes, how did you hear about it and what has been your experience with that?

Suggestions for future strategies to improve food access (10 minutes)

READ TO PARTICIPANT: This is the last section of our interview and I would like to ask your suggestions on how to improve food security among refugees.

1. What do you think keeps people from your community from using food assistance programs that are available to them?

A lot of the programs are farming programs. There are people who are able to farm or have an interest or hobby in it. I am a person who does not know how to farm, has no experience in it. I don't understand. It. A lot of people came from places that were farming area so of course they know how to farm.

FQ: do you think there is anything else that stops people from your community from using food assistance programs available to them?

No

2. How do you think we can ensure that refugees can access food assistance programs when they need help with food?

Of course the person who needs it. IRC has to communicate with the refugee. They have to ask them if they need help if they need food. IRC will not ask if you are in need anything. The care is the problem. They may be able to check and see if you need food and give it to you but of course they are not going to do that. They don't check nor do they ask about you. You have to ask and say that you need food, you

need help. But they don't. If they asked and checked in on you of course the situation would be much better.

FQ: so how exactly can we help refugees?

As an organization you have to share the idea or ask if they need help or don't. Of course he needs help but there is no one who contacts him if he needs help or not.

FQ: how often should communication be?

Some people if they need help, but they don't have time to contact each person individually. There should be a 24 hour phone line or place that the refugee can contact. Its okay if he needs to contact them but there needs to be a means of communication.

3. What do you think <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY> and other refugee organizations can do to ensure refugees have enough food?

They can not ensure it. The problem is that IRC is busy all time time. So you have to depend on yourself and find solutions yourself. You have to find other options. Maybe ask others for money or ask for a loan.

4. Do you want to share anything else regarding your experiences with food insecurity and using food assistance programs since you moved to the U.S. and since you graduated from <RESETTLEMENT AGENCY>?

The people here need help. They need help financially or when it comes to food. There should be more help offered to people. Because there are people whose situations need help in ways that they don't find. For example there are cultural foods that are not available. They are only available at halal markets and the price is way higher than a regular grocery store. The prices are a lot higher than what you find in a regular market. Why? Because the owner will tell you that he got them from sudan or Africa. Importations, taxes they will increase the price. But if it was the same price of course people would be able to buy It but with the financial situation of course they wont be able to buy it a lot.